

Varanus komodoensis

Komodo dragon



Length 6½–9¾ ft (2–3 m)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Terrestrial
Status Vulnerable

Location Indonesia (Komodo, Rinca, Padar, W. Flores)

With an average weight of about 155 lb (70 kg), and sometimes double this in captivity, the Komodo dragon is the world's heaviest lizard. It has a long body, well-developed legs, and a deeply forked tongue, which it flicks out as it searches for food. Juveniles are boldly marked, with gray or cream bands, but lose these markings as they mature, becoming uniformly grayish brown, with thickly folded, scaly skin.

Komodo dragons live on scrubby hillsides and in open woodland and

dry riverbeds, where they feed entirely on live animals or carrion. They have a keen sense of smell, and can detect the scent of decaying remains from up to 3 miles (5 km). However, they hunt mainly by ambushing prey. Young Komodo dragons attack snakes, lizards, and rodents, but adults target much larger prey, including wild pigs, water buffalo, and deer. They are also cannibalistic—one reason why juveniles spend much of their time in trees.

Adults are mainly solitary, although groups may gather at the site of a kill. During the breeding season, males compete for the chance to mate, wrestling in an upright position with their tails acting as props. After mating, females dig nests in sandy ground, laying clutches of up to 25 eggs. When the eggs hatch—about 9 months later—the young are left to fend for themselves. Komodo dragons take about 5 years to become sexually mature, and in the wild they have a maximum lifespan of about 40 years.

ON THE SCENT OF FOOD

Komodo dragons have good eyesight, but they find most of their food by smell. Like snakes, they "taste" the air with their tongues, which collect scent molecules from the air. They have sharp, serrated teeth, but because they cannot chew, they tear off pieces of food and then throw them backward into their mouths. Komodo dragon saliva is rich in toxic bacteria, and it was thought that when a dragon bites an animal, these bacteria contaminate the wound, thus weakening its prey. In 2009, it was found that Komodo dragons actually produce a toxin, responsible for stunning the prey into shock and preventing its blood from clotting.

CONSERVATION

Komodo dragons are the world's most localized large predators, restricted to a few Indonesian islands. Estimated at 2,500–5,000, the population is a fraction of its size 50 years ago. Its decline is due to hunting, loss of prey, and habitat change. However, Komodo dragons have become increasingly important as a tourist attraction, a practical incentive for their conservation.



relatively small head with wide jaws

skin folds on neck

body held off ground when walking

small scales are grayish brown in adults

sharp claws used for digging burrows and unearthing food

A GIANT PREDATOR

Komodo dragons look ungainly, but they are capable of running at up to 11 mph (18 kph) in short bursts. They are also good swimmers. They have a huge capacity for food, eating up to half their own weight in a single meal.

long, muscular tail can be used as a weapon, and as a prop when standing on hindlegs

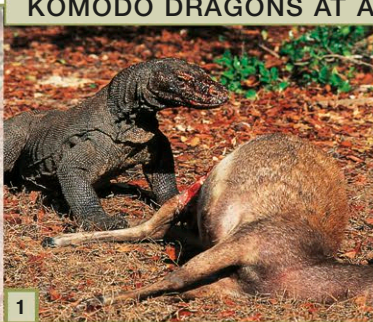
KOMODO DRAGONS AT A KILL



1

FIRST ARRIVAL

Guided by scent, a Komodo dragon homes in on a deer ambushed several hours earlier. The deer escaped, but has since died from the dragon's bite.



2

FEEDING BEGINS

The dragon begins to feed on the deer's body. It has unusually flexible joints between its jaw and skull, enabling it to swallow large chunks of food.



3

QUICK WORK

The dragon feeds rapidly, swallowing flesh, skin, and even bones. Meanwhile, other dragons begin to head for the carcass as its scent drifts downwind.



4

FIGHTING FOR SHARES

As more dragons arrive at the scene, the larger animals try to intimidate the smaller ones into backing away from the kill. If food is scarce, fighting often breaks out.

